

Sunday, July 1st

My father had an incredible gift of vision. He employed it all his life -- as an entrepreneur, father, husband, and mayor. He saw things others did not. This place is was yet another example, and perhaps the culmination of many years of imagining audacious things.

I remember when we saw the property for the first time. We were fishing with Josh on a father-son fishing trip -- the first time we ever visited the river. In just 4 short years, my father had not only built his dream home with his own bare hands, he had become a staple of this wonderful community, and an indelible feature of this river.

My father's favorite book was Jonathan Livingston Seagull. It begins:

"But way off alone, out by himself beyond boat and shore, Jonathan Livingston Seagull was practicing."

My father often practiced, on his own. When he was young, he would throw free throws until he hit so many in a row. He'd hit a tennis ball endlessly against a wall. He'd kick a football as high and as straight as he could into the air, then catch it.

The book goes on to tell the story of a seagull who is bored with daily squabbles over food. He is seized by a passion for flight, and he pushes himself, learning everything he can about flying.

My father was also often seized by passions, and he would become obsessed with perfecting technique. Often in sport, later in business, and certainly in building this place. In some ways, his toiling here was him practicing, endlessly, seized by his passion to build a life and a home integrated into this great wilderness.

Finally, Jonathan Livingston Seagull's unwillingness to conform results in his expulsion. As an outcast, though, he continues to learn, as he leads a peaceful and happy life. Jonathan eventually meets kind of spirit guide, and he discovers that his sheer tenacity and desire to learn make him "pretty well a one-in-a-million bird."

My father was indeed a one-in-a-million bird. He was not an outcast, per se, but set apart by his fits of passion, and his tenacity to see them through.

And this, right here, is where he chose to lead his peaceful, happy life. You all were apart of it. Anytime you waved to him from the river, or otherwise engaged with his infectious, playful joy, you were apart of his this project of perfection.

Indeed, over his life my father was a man of endless projects. On one other such project -- renovating my little home in SF -- my Dad and I would encounter what would become one of his favorite sayings we found together, appropriately, on a poster with a Bald Eagle -- a bird that he would come to love here. It said:

“Excellence is the result of caring more than others think is wise, risking more than others think is safe, dreaming more than others think is practical, and expecting more than others think is possible.”

Here, on this property, you witnessed my father bring his whole heart to bear on a small patch of land. He cared fiercely. He lost himself in a dream. You may have witnessed him risk more than others thought safe -- his tractor overturned right over there.

Ultimately, I think his ability to commit his whole being to a place is precisely what made him so damn likeable. He committed his whole heart to many things. To his family, to his entrepreneurial endeavors, to the small village of which he was Mayor.

And he was committing his whole heart here, too. He loved being a part of this place. He did not just build this beautiful home. He became apart of your community. You embraced him, with all of his quirks, and he embraced you, too.

In Jonathan Livingston Seagull, Jonathan ultimately eschews a life of higher and faster himself flying to return to flocks to teach others how to fly higher and faster. And I think, even if my father did not know it, that he was teaching us, too.

He was teaching us to live wholeheartedly, joyfully, determinedly, and certainly with some degree of flair. As for myself, I know his teaching will be with me for the remainder of my life.

As Josh has said, the river will not be the same without him. Not for us here. Certainly not for me and my mother. His light burned so brightly.

I think it is fitting that his silo (that one) -- so strange, and so quintessentially *him* -- acts as a kind of beacon to this valley. He graced this place for just a few short years, but his presence will be seen for miles. Anytime you travel on Highway 26, and you see this silver beacon, you can think on my father's presence here, and on the things he might have taught you.

I had hoped to share this place with my future family. I had planned for us to fish together like I had fished with my father and his. Today, I was lucky to enjoy the river with dear friends, courtesy of the guides that first showed my father and me this river. I hope in the years that follow, we can do this place justice, and that my mother and I can be friends to you, if only in some small part, as my father was. I expect for my family to enjoy this river, to partake in this community, for a long time to come.

In Jonathan Livingston Seagull, the Elder Gull says to Jonathan:

"You will begin to touch heaven , Jonathan, in the moment that you touch perfect speed. And that isn't flying a thousand miles an hour, or a million, or flying at the speed of light. Because any number is a limit, and perfection doesn't have limits. Perfect speed, my son, is being there. "

Jonathan then muses:

The trick was to know that his true nature lived, as perfect as an unwritten number, everywhere at once across space and time.
